

10 Best Hidden Gems In Europe

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Named Travel Influencer of the Year in 2022

If I can recommend you skip the obvious and visit a lesser-known destination, it'll help disperse the crowds, support communities in other areas and improve tourism around the world. Well, that's the dream!

After several years of extensive travel around Europe, I've come up with a pretty comprehensive list of options for you. Beautiful places, great suggestions for road trips and day trips and a mix of beaches, mountains, lakes, villages, towns and cities. There really is something for everyone in here!

Cadiz, Spain

If you were asked to name some Spanish cities, I'm guessing you'd say Barcelona, Madrid, Seville and maybe Valencia? Unless you've been to Cadiz, it's probably not a city you'd think of, and yet I'm putting it out there – it's one of my favourite places in the whole of Spain, and I've visited a lot of beautiful spots in the country!

So why visit [Cadiz](#)? If you're into history, this is the city for you. Founded by the Phoenicians 3,000 years ago, Cadiz is one of the oldest cities in Western Europe. The Romans also settled there, building an impressive city (some of which is still in existence today).

But there's more to this city than its past. There are several beautiful beaches, including La Caleta right in the centre. There are wiggly narrow streets, beautiful tree-lined plazas, fountains, great restaurants and sensational views.

While some of Spain's larger cities are becoming more multi-cultural, Cadiz has retained a truly Andalusian flavour and charm. I'd recommend visiting for 3 nights, spending your days exploring on foot at your own pace. You won't regret it.

Siurana, Spain

The drive to the village of Siurana in Catalonia was a highlight of my trip to the [Costa Dorada](#). Away from the beach-loving crowds in Salou, it was amazing to escape to somewhere with such epic scenery.

After a wiggly drive up to the Prades Mountains, enjoying dry, arid views of dusty orange sandstone and beautiful vineyards, we arrived at the top of the mountain. The tiny village of Siurana is home to just 24 people, some of whom run the [6-room hotel](#) and restaurant.

With the ruins of a Moorish castle constructed in 800 and a simple 12th century Romanesque church with a baroque altar, there's plenty of history to marvel at.

The highlights for me were the views, with sheer drops all around, and spectacular panoramas to the vibrant turquoise reservoir below. The village is adorable too, with old stone houses and romantic cobble streets.

Siurana is one of the prettiest villages in Catalonia, and while it can get busy in peak tourist season (I heard coach tours visit) if you visit on a weekday (like I did) you might have the place to yourself.

Saxon-Switzerland, Germany

30km southeast of Dresden lies a region of Germany that will have you muttering "that doesn't look like Germany!" Germany isn't just beautiful castles, Christmassy villages, forests and mountains.

In Saxon Switzerland you'll come face to face with huge sandstone rocks, magical forests and countryside.

Many of the rock formations are around 200m tall and were formed a million years ago. They've been a huge draw for travellers and tourists over the years,

so much so that in 1824 a wooden bridge was constructed to allow people to explore the area more easily.

This was later replaced in 1851 by the sandstone bridge known as the [Bastei Bridge](#) that stands in place today. It looks like something from the pages of a fairytale!

If you love the outdoors, this is a great region to visit – even better if you're into hiking or climbing. I loved exploring on foot. And yes, I definitely found myself saying "this doesn't look like Germany!"

Lake Bohinj, Slovenia

If you were to visit Slovenia's most famous spot you'd probably head straight for Lake Bled, with its tiny island topped with a church. It's stunning, romantic and worthy of its popularity.

But what if I told you there was another lake under 30 minutes away, which is just as stunning, but hasn't got the same crowds visiting?

Lake Bohinj was one of the highlights of my trip to Slovenia. I remember the mirror-like reflections on the water and the beautiful snow-covered mountains surrounding it. I loved the low-hanging mist too – a stunning sight, and the reason I took so many photos!

Vogel Ski Resort, Slovenia

Talking about Lake Bohinj in the Julian Alps brings me on nicely to this spot! I've mentioned the mountains around the lake, and it turns out you can actually ski on some of them. This is where you'll find Vogel – one of Slovenia's premier ski resorts.

Did you know Slovenia had a ski resort? Vogel Ski Resort is one of my favourite secret places in Europe

It has over 22km of ski slopes, 9 lifts and a top altitude of 1800m. Depending on the weather it's usually open from early December to the start of April. If you're looking for a hidden gem in Europe for skiing, you've found your spot!

Mdina, Malta

There's more to Malta than the city of Valletta. When we visited Malta last autumn we went on a day trip to Mdina. Friends had recommended the walled city to us, and it was easy to reach by public bus from Valletta.

Mdina was the capital city of Malta up until medieval times and is one of Europe's finest examples of an ancient walled city. It's enclosed in tall walls, and is filled with tiny streets filled containing historic stone buildings.

We wandered around for the afternoon, stopping for pizza topped with truffle at a cute restaurant near the main square, followed by coffee and a cake by the viewpoint. There are gorgeous views from one side of the walled city – you'll definitely be reaching for your camera.

I also loved the colours of Mdina. While the buildings are a sandy colour, many of the doors are painted in bright colours. It's a very photogenic place, and a nice change of scene if you're staying in Valletta.

Tallinn, Estonia

The only capital city to make it onto my list of hidden gems in Europe, and yes, I'm aware it might take a bit of explaining. After all, how can a country's most important city be remotely secret? Well, I don't know, maybe it isn't, but when I visited, I hadn't heard anyone ever recommend it before, and I absolutely fell in love with the place! It's photogenic, fun and there's plenty to do.

During my time there it wasn't remotely busy and felt very un-touristy. Perhaps it was the time of year (September) or maybe it is wonderfully underrated!

Tallinn is a remarkably well-preserved medieval city, complete with ancient city walls made from limestone, a picturesque town hall, and brightly coloured buildings lining cobble streets. I loved the mix of old and new. While the

architecture may take you back in time, there's a heavy influence on modern design and décor, as well as some cool cafes and bars around the city.

If you've been to a lot of the obvious cities in Europe, I'd recommend Tallinn for your next city break.

Saas-Fee, Switzerland

Saas-Fee is a popular ski resort in Switzerland, but you can visit the town all year round. It tends to be pretty quiet in the summer, so is a genuine hidden gem for an outdoorsy trip at that time of year.

[We visited](#) in peak winter though and even though we weren't skiing, we still loved exploring the snow-covered town. The highlight was visiting Mittelallalin – a 3,500 peak just below Allalinhorn (accessible via 2 cable cars and a train).

The panoramic views from the viewing platform were absolutely mesmerising. We also enjoyed frothy hot chocolates inside Allalin Restaurant – the world's highest revolving restaurant.

South Downs, England

A few months ago, I visited another truly beautiful part of my home country – the [South Downs National Park](#).

The national park spans a whopping 1600 square kilometres, stretching from Winchester in the west all the way to Eastbourne in the east. The thing I love about it? The huge variety of landscapes. You'll find stunning vistas of rolling hills, heaths, vineyards, farms and ancient forests, as well as epic cliffs and beaches.

It's also a region famed for its dark skies. With little light pollution, there's a chance to enjoy some incredible stargazing – something we absolutely loved doing!

Highlights included the walk through Kingley Vale's 2000 year old grove, filled with the tangled, twisty branches of ancient yew trees. We stayed at [The Old](#)

[Railway Station](#) – a former station that has been converted into an incredible B&B with old Pullman carriages for bedrooms. It's one of the quirkiest places I've ever stayed!

Since that trip we've returned to the South Downs National Park again to hike from [Eastbourne to Beachy Head](#). It's a beautiful route which takes in some of the best chalk cliff views in England.

Jurassic Coast, England

Many visitors to England head straight for London, followed by [Windsor](#), Oxford, Cambridge, Bath and York. Don't get me wrong – these are all gorgeous places to visit, but how about a coastal trip to remember?

[Dorset's Jurassic Coast](#) is one of my new favourite regions of England. There are lots of places I'd recommend exploring. [Durdle Door](#) is the most popular stop on the coast and is anything but a hidden gem, so how about visiting Old Harry Rocks instead? Set off from Studland Bay and in around 30 minutes you'll reach the huge chalk standing stones. Views are stunning and it's a lovely way to spend an afternoon.

The beach in West Bay is famous for its huge sandstone cliffs, with 140 ft sheer drops to the ground below. The ridges on the cliffs are a reminder of why this is known as the Jurassic Coast, as they show the falling sea levels from over 175 million years ago.

